▼ JNUSU president Aishe Ghosh speaks to the press a day after the 2020 attack



PANKAJ NANGIA

The Beaten Path

JNU UPRISING, 2016, 2020

Delhi

In 2016, Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) students gathered to protest the capital punishment meted out to 2001 Parliament attack convict Afzal Guru, leading to the arrest of students' union president Kanhaiya Kumar and two others. The arrests, it was alleged, were the BJP-led Centre's attempt to silence dissent. Protests were held in college campuses in many other states in solidarity. Investigations carried out by the Delhi government and JNU revealed the controversial slogans had been raised by outsiders. The arrested students were granted bail. However, after 21 students were charged with violating university rules and punitive action taken against them, the students went on a hunger strike. The Delhi High Court suspended the punitive action on the condition that the students end the strike.

Protests erupted again when on January 5, 2020, masked assailants attacked JNU students and staff. Most victims claimed it was orchestrated by the ABVP. After the attack, students began protest marches in Delhi, Bengaluru, Mumbai, Kolkata and Hyderabad in solidarity with JNU victims. ■

– Kaushik Deka

FIRING UP THE CAMPUS
The JNU protests have given fresh impetus to campus politics in India. The country acquired a new set of emerging leaders, among them Kanhaiya Kumar, who is now a Congress leader in Bihar

Students vs. the Patriarchy

BHU PROTESTS, 2017

Varanasi

RAJESH KUMAR/GETTY IMAGES



◀ BHU students face off with the police, Sept. 24, 2017

SAME DIFFERENCE
More than four years after the incident, one can scarcely claim that the issue of women's safety across campuses has been resolved in any way

In September 2017, a female student of the Banaras Hindu University reported an incident of sexual harassment to the hostel authorities. Instead of taking action, the authorities berated the young girl for being out late. When students staged a *dharna* outside the vice-chancellor's residence, the police lathi-charged them, resulting in some students and journalists getting injured. This only hardened the students' stand, and the protests soon spread to Delhi.

The 2017 protests brought to the fore security issues at campuses across India and the patriarchal response to complaints on matters like sexual harassment. More than a year later, the BHU administration debarred 11 students who were part of the protests from seeking admission to the university in future. A probe panel headed by a retired high court judge gave a clean chit to the BHU administration and called the protests sponsored. ■

–Rahul Noronha

The authorities took no action on the sexual harassment complaint and instead chastised the victim for being out late